

EDUCATION STRATEGY

Shaping the Future of Learning

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SEPTEMBER 2026

unicef  | for every child

This paper complements the existing Education Strategy (2019-2030) by clarifying the priorities, operating model, and partnerships needed to accelerate learning, equity, and skills for all children and adolescents. As such, this strategy presents a roadmap for implementation of UNICEF's Strategic Plan 2026-2029.

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Abbreviations and Acronyms

ADB	Asian Development Bank
AfDB	African Development Bank
AI	Artificial intelligence
AISC	Inter-Agency Standing Committee
CO	Country Office
CoE	Centre of Excellence
CRPD	Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities
DIPAS	Disability Inclusion Policy and Strategy
ECCE	Early Childhood Care and Education
ECD	Early Childhood Development
ECE	Early Childhood Education
ECW	Education Cannot Wait
EdTech	Education technology
EU	European Union
FCDO	Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office
GBC	Global Business Coalition
GPE	Global Partnership for Education
IDB	Inter-American Development Bank
ILO	International Labour Organization
INGO	International Non-Governmental Organization
JICA	Japan International Cooperation Agency
MHM	Menstrual Hygiene Management
MoE	Ministry of Education
NNGO	National Non-Governmental Organization
NORAD	Norwegian Agency for Development Cooperation
NRC	Norwegian Refugee Council
QFFD	Qatar Fund for Development
RC	Resident Coordinator
RO	Regional Office
SBC	Social and Behavioural Change
SDG	Sustainable Development Goal
SIDA	Swedish International Development Cooperation Agency
SP	Strategic Plan
TA	Technical assistance
TaRL	Teaching at the Right Level
TVET	Technical and Vocational Education and Training
UN	United Nations
UNCT	United Nations Country Team
UNESCO	United Nations Education Scientific and Cultural Organization
UNGEI	United Nations Girls' Education Initiative
UNHCR	United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees
UNICEF	United Nations Children's Fund
WASH	Water, sanitation and hygiene
WFP	World Food Programme
WHO	World Health Organization



The Unmissable Opportunity

With less than five years remaining until the 2030 SDG4 deadline, the global learning crisis is the defining challenge of this generation. Globally, education systems are not delivering expected learning outcomes for the majority of the world's children, and the cost of inaction grows every year. A more fundamental question is emerging, as to whether the school itself, designed for a different era, can deliver the learning that today's children need and deserve. UNICEF's experience points to the need to rethink how and where children learn.

A range of converging advances make this moment decisive. Neuroscience now illuminates with greater definition and clarity how children learn, remember, and develop across the life course, insights unavailable when today's school systems were designed. The science of teaching has advanced substantially, producing evidence-based pedagogies that reliably improve learning outcomes. Education technology and AI, with solutions that are adapted to context, usable offline or in low-bandwidth environments where needed, can strengthen teaching and support more equitable education systems, helping bridge persistent barriers such as language, accessibility for children with disabilities, geographic isolation, gender inequalities, disruptions to schooling, and the longstanding challenge of meeting children at their actual learning levels. Powerful data and information systems now allow governments to track student progress, identify gaps, and

make evidence-informed policy and budget decisions in real time. These modalities, applied at scale, can support governments to create learner-centred learning environments, bridge learning disruptions, and reach every child regardless of circumstance. If UNICEF seizes this window to lay the foundation for systemic reform, the vision is achievable.

With 80 years of programming experience, in humanitarian and development contexts, country and global presence, and standard-setting authority, UNICEF is positioned to support governments in leading that reform and shaping the future of learning at scale.

This paper sets out UNICEF's vision for addressing both challenges and opportunities in a period of profound change. It complements the existing Education Strategy (2019-2030) by clarifying the priorities, operating model, and partnerships needed to accelerate learning, equity, and skills for all children and adolescents. As such, this paper presents a roadmap for implementation of UNICEF's Strategic Plan 2026-2029 and the achievement of its education results (see Box 1). It is intended to guide UNICEF's global, regional, and country-level support to governments, while remaining adaptable to context and aligned with national leadership and broader system actors.

BOX 1 2026-2029 Strategic Plan Targets: Education**Impact Result 2****350 million more children and young people learning and skilled****200 million more**

children and adolescents in school (pre-primary to secondary), of whom 100 million are girls and 15 million are children with disabilities.

120 million more

children, of whom 60 million are girls, achieving minimum learning proficiency levels.

160 million more

young people, of whom 80 million are adolescent girls and young women, acquiring skills for work and life.

The UNICEF Advantage: Global Influence, Local Delivery, Measurable Results

Education reform that addresses the learning crisis by leveraging these advances is both strategic and deeply human.

UNICEF can accelerate this reform because it has the proven track record of shaping, defining and advancing with governments national and global education agendas anchored in children's rights, equity, and the transformation of education systems. From declaring education a fundamental right (1989) to the World Conference on Education for All (1990), Child Friendly Schools (2000), championing girls' education, and co-leading the global education cluster in humanitarian contexts, UNICEF has shaped watershed moments in global education.

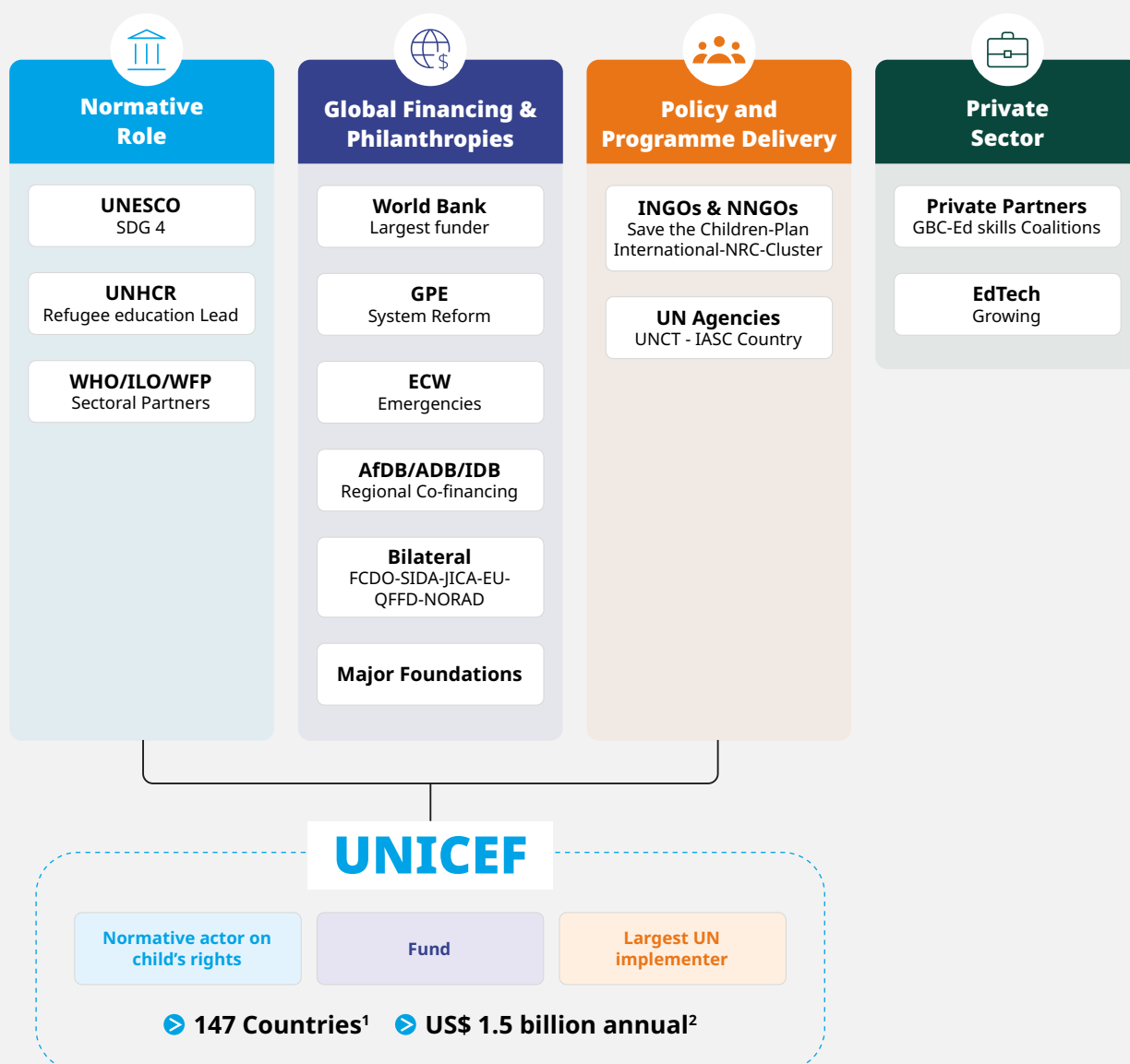
UNICEF is one of the world's largest operational actors in education, particularly in humanitarian and crisis contexts, where it is often the provider of learning support and last resort. This dual role, as a norm setter and frontline implementer, has established UNICEF as a trusted system-wide leader, coordinator, convener, and partner with unmatched reach across both development and humanitarian settings. With its unparalleled presence from global to community levels, UNICEF works across the entire chain of change, generating and applying evidence, shaping policy, convening partners and supporting implementation on the ground to drive sustainable improvements in learning. Further, UNICEF's multi-sectoral programming

across health, nutrition, child protection, social protection, gender, and WASH creates synergies with direct implications for learning outcomes that no other education actor can offer. This multi-sectorality allows UNICEF to approach education reform as a whole-child imperative, not a sector-specific challenge, however it has not yet been consistently leveraged in service of education results.

The global education architecture (see Figure 1) is structured around three broad categories of actors: humanitarian responders, long-term development partners, and global public goods providers.

While the architecture has matured considerably in recent years, it has also become increasingly fragmented, with overlapping mandates, duplicative mechanisms and growing coordination burdens at global and country levels. These challenges are compounded by declining aid volumes, a proliferation of emergencies and increasingly complex financing channels. Achieving SDG 4 and advancing a new education paradigm requires the combined strengths of the UN system and a broad coalition of partners. With its unique combination of normative influence, financing leverage, operational presence, technical

Figure 1 Education Architecture: Government Leadership at the Centre





excellence and convening power, UNICEF is well positioned to strengthen coherence across the education ecosystem, working in complementarity with partners at the national and global levels.

Critically, UNICEF's country's presence is both operational and political. UNICEF Representatives and staff engage heads of state, ministers and national planners to position education as a national priority, not merely a technical programme. This provides the foundation for UNICEF to exercise system leadership by:

- i. strengthening its strategic role across the global education ecosystem, working with UNESCO, GPE, ECW, the World Bank, regional organizations such as the African Union and European Union, and civil society to reduce fragmentation and improve coherence; and
- ii. leveraging its country leadership to translate global commitments into national results, align humanitarian and development financing, and forge strategic partnerships with development banks, the private sector and emerging donors to advance long-term outcomes.

In this context, UNICEF's newly established Centres of Excellence will serve as enabling platforms that connect evidence, innovation, technical assistance, funding, and implementation experience across regions and countries. Rather than establishing parallel technical structures, they will complement and reinforce existing global and regional mechanisms with partners, helping to translate global evidence and policy priorities into action at scale at the country level while promoting greater system coherence.

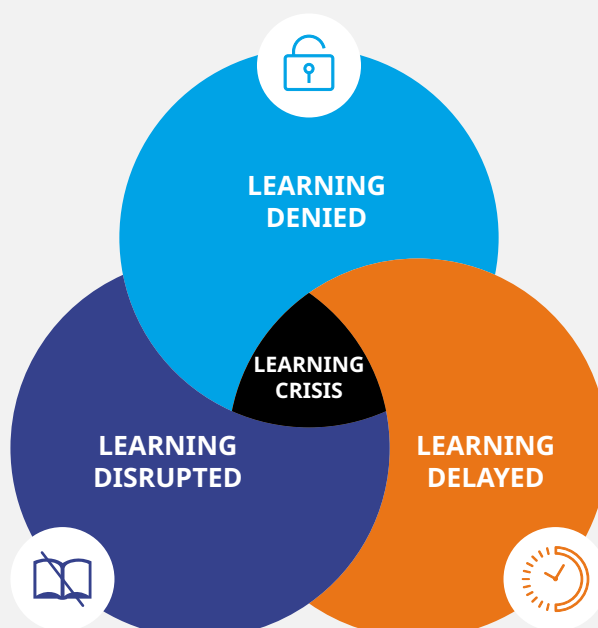
Aligned with UNICEF's Strategic Plan 2026–2029 and building on the global Education Strategy³, UNICEF is extending its leadership into a new era defined by urgency, innovation, and transformation. The focus is on three critical system failures: learning denied, learning delayed, and learning disrupted. UNICEF's vision is to address these challenges through evidence-based, future-ready skills, aligned with today's learners. From early childhood to adolescence, from crisis response to learning continuity, UNICEF will accelerate scalable, innovative solutions grounded in equity to advance every child's right to quality education.

The Urgency for Change

The education system is failing three-quarters of the world's children. At age 5, close to 75 per cent of children are developmentally on track. By age 18, only 25 per cent have the required skills for life and work. The three interrelated failures drive the global learning crisis (see Figure 2):

- Learning Denied:** 29 million 5-year-olds are excluded from any organized early learning and over 273 million primary and secondary school-age children are out of school, due to structural issues such as lack of access, poverty, gender norms and sociocultural constraints, ethnolinguistic disadvantages, migration, refugee movements, climate and environmental degradation and humanitarian crises⁴.
- Learning Disrupted:** Learning is being interrupted due to conflict, climate, pandemic related and other causes and circumstances, leading to learning loss and dropout. In 2024 alone, nearly a quarter of a billion had their education upended due to climate impacts. Furthermore, 234 million school-aged children and adolescents in crisis settings require urgent education support. Marginalized children, particularly girls, residing in climate hotspots are disproportionately affected by the adverse consequences of erratic weather patterns. These effects extend beyond disruption to education, and jeopardize their mental well-being, food security, and livelihoods.

Figure 2 Three Interrelated Failures Drive the Learning Crisis



- **Learning Delayed:** An estimated 70 per cent of 10-year-olds in low- and middle-income countries cannot read and comprehend a basic sentence. Children and young people are in school but not acquiring relevant knowledge and skills at the expected level. This is primarily due to poor education quality driven by systemic challenges, including limited human and financial resources, inadequate teacher training, inequitable teacher distribution, outdated school models and pedagogies, and insufficient learning resources⁵. These foundational learning gaps continue into adolescence, limiting young people's ability to continue secondary education, access skills training, and decent work. Only about half of the world's children today reach upper-secondary education on time, and the majority of these late-entry and over-age adolescents tend to experience higher rates of repetition, disengagement and dropping-out.

These failures amplify each other. A girl from a poor household lagging in grade-level skills who experiences climate-related learning disruption is far more likely to drop out and miss the opportunity to acquire relevant skills. She, in turn, may be pushed into negative coping strategies such as early marriage, unsafe migration, child labour or informal work without adequate protection. Children with disabilities and those living in crisis-affected countries are particularly vulnerable to all three failures. External and geopolitical factors

continuously intensify these interconnected system failures and present a troubling trend of deprioritization of education on the global agenda.

The result is a learning crisis that is not only failing children today, but also weakening the human capital on which future prosperity, resilience, and social cohesion depend. Education is both a fundamental right and one of the most important investments countries can make in their people. Yet when children do not learn, the returns to years spent in school are diminished, limiting individual opportunities and constraining broader economic and social development. This trajectory can be reversed. By transforming how education systems reach children, support teachers, deliver learning, and build skills, countries can unlock the full potential of every child and strengthen the foundations for sustainable growth and development.

Against this background, UNICEF's goal is that by 2030, more than 350 million children and young people are learning and acquiring skills, with a particular focus on children from the poorest households, adolescent girls, children with disabilities, and those affected by crisis. Achieving this goal will require bold education reforms that tackle the root causes of the learning crisis and deliver better learning outcomes while recognizing education as a critical investment in human capital, economic productivity, and social progress.

Proposed Solution: 2 Paradigm Shifts

To address these system failures, UNICEF will leverage the advances of the 21st century, its unique position in the education architecture, and the Future Focus Reform to support governments in achieving the 2030 targets.

This requires two paradigm shifts, grounded in the evidence of what works,⁶ across UNICEF's programming and coordination experience: Shift 1 focuses on the "what", and Shift 2 on the "how."

Shift 1: What UNICEF Delivers - Transforming Learning Through Systemic Enablers

For impact, UNICEF's programmatic focus needs to have a big push on closing results gaps across the critical transitions of the learning cycle, especially for populations who are most at risk of getting left behind. A strategic emphasis will be on putting quality teaching and learning at the center, as well as harnessing AI and education technology responsibly.

Elevating Teaching Workforce Development

Teachers are the primary agents of educational transformation. Yet the profession is under strain: status has eroded; working conditions have deteriorated; deployment is inequitable; and accountability systems are weak or absent. Too many teachers enter classrooms or learning spaces underprepared or unqualified and remain underserved throughout their careers, not because of individual failure, but because of systemic policies that have never been designed to fully support them. In humanitarian contexts, this gap is most acute. Community and volunteer teachers, who are often the only available educators in crisis settings, operate almost entirely outside formal support structures, without training pathways, professional recognition, or psychosocial support for their own needs.

UNICEF will support governments to advance comprehensive reform of the teaching profession across five interconnected dimensions.

- First, renewing personal and professional development across pre-service and in-service continuum: moving beyond fragmented training toward holistic, continuous growth that links directly to learning outcomes.
- Second, professionalizing teaching: modernizing the profession's status, pathways, and working conditions so it can

attract, retain, and motivate the people children deserve.

- Third, strengthening deployment and management: ensuring transparent, equitable, and data-driven systems that put the right teachers where they are needed most.
- Fourth, building meaningful accountability: a system of feedback, support, and shared responsibility for children's learning.
- Fifth, supporting teachers in humanitarian and crisis contexts: recognizing community and volunteer teachers as essential to the profession, equipping them with adapted training and mental health and psychosocial support, and creating pathways for their integration into formal systems as stability returns.

Equitable and Responsible Use of AI and Education Technology

Digital technologies, including artificial intelligence (AI), are reshaping education at a critical moment with both significant promise and substantial risk. While it could support teachers, personalize learning, monitor student learning and expand access, current models are trained primarily on languages and contexts from a few countries. Without deliberate action, AI and EdTech risk reinforcing existing inequalities, widening digital divides, and further marginalizing learners in low-resource settings characterized by limited connectivity, unreliable electricity, and weak digital infrastructure. UNICEF will prioritize areas where AI and EdTech demonstrably add value to teaching and learning. They are a system-level lever, beyond digital learning per se, that operate across the full continuum from emergency response to recovery, resilience, and proactive system reform. UNICEF will uplift the voice of young people towards future-proofing education with these tools. The current risks of technology need to be managed and mitigated, including that AI models are trained primarily on languages and contexts from a small number of countries, and without deliberate intervention, they risk deepening the very inequities that need to be addressed.

UNICEF will enable a coordinated approach to shape AI and EdTech as tools for equity across five interconnected areas.

- First, stewarding responsible development: working with governments and the private sector to place children at the centre of national AI strategies, with clear standards for equity, transparency, data protection, and learning impact.
- Second, ensuring Global South representation: AI tools must be designed for, trained on, and accountable to linguistic diversity, local curricula, cultural relevance, and low-resource realities, including multilingual and offline environments.
- Third, keeping teachers at the centre: AI must amplify rather than replace teachers, reducing administrative burden, enabling personalized instruction, and generating actionable insights into learner progress. Teacher recruitment, training, and retention remain foundational.
- Fourth, reaching every child across the continuum: from crisis and displacement to stable development contexts, AI and EdTech must be accessible to all children through offline-capable, low-bandwidth solutions in fragile settings and scalable tools where infrastructure allows.
- Fifth, preparing adolescents for an AI-enabled world: personalized remedial support, AI-enabled tutoring, and

transformed secondary learning pathways that build the capacities young people will need for life and work.

UNICEF's approach to leveraging AI and EdTech is in service of better teaching and stronger systems.

These two strategic shifts will be applied across the three programme areas and the cross-cutting strategies.

Programme Areas

Early Childhood and Foundational

Learning: Building on evidence of rapid brain development in the first and second thousand days⁷, UNICEF will promote a continuum of learning and development from birth through adolescence, recognizing early childhood development, care and pre-primary education as integral to achieving foundational learning and lifelong outcomes. UNICEF will support governments to demonstrate and act on the evidence that foundational learning begins at pre-primary, elevate parental engagement, and quality childcare and pre-primary education, advocate for the benchmark of 10 per cent of the public education budget for pre-primary⁸, and strengthen the capacity of caregivers and early childhood education teachers.

UNICEF will intensify support to governments on literacy, numeracy, playful learning and socio-emotional skills as the foundation for

BOX 2 Out-of-school Adolescent Girls

87.5 million adolescent girls of secondary school age are not in school.

They face barriers of poverty, child marriage, and safety concerns. UNICEF will support governments and community to bring these girls back to learning through tailored pathways, including programs leading to employment, and by removing barriers such as school fees. Keeping girls in school requires safe environments, gender-responsive curricula and pedagogies, access to digital devices, and addressing harmful social norms through collective action with communities, local leaders, and influencers.

all future learning and skills development. Through Foundational Learning 2.0, UNICEF will support evidence-based teaching approaches, including structured pedagogy, Teaching at the Right Level (TaRL), and other proven methodologies, and digital technologies that meet learners where they are, including, education in emergencies, older children and adolescents who have missed foundational skills. This will include practical, age-appropriate catch-up approaches that connect literacy and numeracy to real-life tasks. UNICEF will also promote strategies that prevent dropout, support re-entry to learning, and strengthen successful transitions from pre-primary to primary, and primary to secondary.

Central to this UNICEF will support strengthening learning assessment and data systems so that countries can track children's learning, identify gaps, and make evidence-informed decisions at classroom, district and national levels. UNICEF will support the development of interoperable, real-time platforms that connect learning data across levels of the system and generate the evidence base for pro-equity budget and policy decisions. UNICEF will also support governments to embed proven foundational learning approaches into national curricula, teacher professional development systems, and education sector plans ensuring that effective classroom practice is reflected in system-level policy and financing.

Secondary Education: Reclaiming the Missing Middle. Secondary education has historically occupied the “missing middle” of the global education architecture, often underfunded relative to both primary and tertiary levels. Only one in six countries is on track to achieve universal secondary completion by 2030, with 40 per cent of adolescents still left behind. As the critical bridge between foundational learning and future employment and civic participation, secondary education demands urgent attention. Systems are transforming, with reforms emphasizing competency-based curricula, transferable skills, digital readiness, and more flexible academic and vocational pathways. To be effective and relevant, these transformations must be informed by

the voices, experiences, and aspirations of adolescents themselves, recognizing them as active partners in shaping the education systems that serve them.

Building on foundational learning, UNICEF will support countries to transform secondary education systems through stronger policies, sustainable financing, and improved data, assessment and implementation of mechanisms that increase participation, completion and learning outcomes. This includes strengthening secondary education, modernizing TVET as part of an integrated skills ecosystem, reforming curricula and assessment frameworks, investing in teacher development, expanding career guidance and establishing accredited alternative and flexible pathways for out-of-school adolescents and youth. UNICEF will also promote meaningful adolescent participation in education planning, policy dialogue and school improvement processes, ensuring that learners help shape curricula, learning environments and pathways that respond to their evolving needs and ambitions.

Scalable digital and AI-enabled solutions will be leveraged to expand access, personalize learning and improve system effectiveness. In contexts where large numbers of adolescents have not acquired foundational literacy and numeracy, UNICEF will promote sequenced and flexible pathways that combine accelerated learning, remedial education, transferable and socio-emotional skills, financial literacy, digital competencies, and practical vocational exposure.

Out-of-School Children. For the over 300 million children denied learning, UNICEF will strengthen policy advocacy and support governments to leverage big data, satellite and geospatial tracking, and connectivity solutions to identify, reach and retain children in remote areas, children on the move, and those at greatest risk of exclusion. High-level advocacy and policy reform to address structural inequities and exclusionary policies will be combined with community engagement and social and behaviour change approaches that address harmful social norms, discrimination and other barriers to participation.

Preventing dropout is one of the most cost-effective strategies for reducing the number of out-of-school children. UNICEF will support governments to identify early warning signs of disengagement, strengthen school retention, and address the financial, social and learning barriers that push children out of education, including through multi-shift schools and community learning centres. Cross-sectoral partnerships will be strengthened, particularly with social protection, WASH, menstrual health and hygiene, and gender programmes, to address the interconnected drivers of exclusion. Diversified learning modalities, including flexible, blended, digital and remote learning solutions, will be expanded for children on the move and those affected by crisis and conflict, ensuring continuity of learning and pathways to recognized qualifications.

Cross-cutting Strategies

Girls, Inclusive Education and Programming for the Most Disadvantaged. UNICEF will advocate to drive equity for children from the poorest households, girls, boys, children with disabilities, ethnic and linguistic minorities, and refugee and displaced populations through inclusive and resilient education systems with targeted policies and practices for those facing the greatest disadvantage.

UNICEF will strengthen the identification and inclusion of out-of-school girls through improved data tracking and analysis, demand-creation efforts, policy reforms that advance universal education, and the expansion of alternative and flexible learning pathways that support participation, retention and completion. UNICEF will advance gender equality in and through education by supporting gender-responsive pedagogy, curricula and teacher development, preventing and responding to school-related gender-based violence, expanding girls' access to and completion of secondary education, addressing boys' disengagement, and fostering movement-building partnerships including through UNGEI to accelerate collective action and systems change.

UNICEF will promote disability-inclusive education through a twin-track approach that embeds disability inclusion across education policy, sector analysis, planning, financing, curricula and assessment, data systems, AI and education technology, and social and behaviour change initiatives, while supporting targeted measures to address the specific barriers faced by children with disabilities. This includes CRPD-aligned policy and financing reforms, strengthened inclusive pedagogy, universally designed curricula and assessments, assistive technology, and individualized supports where required.

Multi-sectoral approaches will be strengthened across all workstreams to address the interconnected barriers affecting the most marginalized children and adolescents, with particular attention to the intersecting disadvantages of gender, disability, displacement and poverty.

Continuity and Stability: Crisis and climate and environmental risks are now structural features of the education landscape, not episodic disruptions. In 2024, a quarter of a billion children had their schooling interrupted by climate impacts. Conflict and displacement affect hundreds of millions more. These are not temporary conditions requiring temporary responses. They require stronger education systems, and UNICEF's programming within them, to be designed for disruption from the outset. UNICEF's response operates across two interconnected areas:

- **Climate resilience.** UNICEF will support governments in designing climate-resilient school infrastructure and deploy digital solutions, including portable connectivity and energy-efficient hardware, that ensure learning continues when physical schools are compromised. Climate change curricula, including a focus on regenerative agriculture nutritious diets, youth-led action programmes, school-based disaster risk reduction and environmentally sustainable school design will be integrated into national education planning rather than treated as supplementary components. The flagship initiative, "100,000 climate-resilient schools" will be the lighthouse for this work. This will enable climate literacy and disaster



risk awareness to be integrated in curricula and workforce capacity.

- **Conflict, displacement, and protracted crisis.** Children affected by conflict, forced displacement, and protracted crises represent the most educationally marginalized population globally, and their exclusion from quality learning is both a consequence and a driver of fragility. UNICEF's approach is grounded in the humanitarian-development-peace nexus, ensuring that even acute emergency responses are framed within a systems-strengthening trajectory, and that education is actively leveraged as a tool for saving and sustaining lives, social cohesion, community stabilization, and peacebuilding. This means integrating Education in Emergencies and resilience planning into national education sector plans from the outset, and bridging humanitarian and development responses in ways that build toward durable national systems rather than parallel structures. The current reset⁹ context is accelerating transitions out of humanitarian coordination architecture in a significant number of countries, creating both pressure and opportunity. UNICEF will accompany governments through these transitions, supporting them to absorb functions previously coordinated through the cluster and to embed resilience within national systems. UNICEF will provide technical assistance and coordination leadership across all phases of humanitarian action, from preparedness to response and recovery ensuring continuity of systems-strengthening intent throughout. Mental health and psychosocial support, as well as safety from violence in schools, are integrated components of this approach, not supplementary additions.
- **Coordination of Education Emergencies:** UNICEF will continue to ensure it fulfills its IASC accountabilities and core functions as a Cluster Lead Agency globally and at country level. This will be underpinned, via its co-leadership role in the Global Education Cluster, through support to coordination and information management, strengthening coordination capacities, knowledge and evidence generation and advocacy.

Shift 2: How UNICEF Will Work Differently - A New Operating Model for Education

Delivering on this vision requires a fundamental shift in how UNICEF operates, moving beyond traditional approaches, project-level interventions to systems-focused approaches to contribute to drive sustainable and scalable education outcomes. Across diverse contexts, UNICEF has already supported reforms that leverage domestic and external resources, strengthen national systems, and improve how education is financed and delivered for the long term. To **accelerate and deepen** this work across the organization, UNICEF will focus on **two complementary dimensions**: mobilizing and aligning financing for education reform at scale, and providing agile, world-class technical, operational, and coordination support through Centres of Excellence (CoE).

Dimension 1: Financing Education Reform at Scale

Achieving sustainable learning outcomes requires UNICEF to operate with strategic intent across the full financing architecture of education systems: how governments plan and spend, how large-scale capital is mobilized, and how private sector investment is aligned with public education goals. Piecemeal engagement is no longer sufficient. UNICEF's financing strategy is organized around two mutually reinforcing areas.

Accompanying Governments on Budget Reform, grounded in learning assessments

Domestic public finance is the only financing source with the scale, predictability, and sustainability to drive systemic education reform. In one out of every three countries, debt servicing now costs more than education. Development assistance is declining. The \$97 billion dollar annual financing gap for SDG4 cannot be closed from the outside. Closing the gap also requires governments to extract greater value from existing resources through locally driven innovations:

multi-shift schooling, multi-grade teaching, community learning centres, and flexible scheduling models that expand access without proportional increases in cost. UNICEF will support governments to identify, test, and scale these approaches as part of its budget accompaniment work.

UNICEF will work with governments to strengthen domestic resource mobilization, advance budget reforms, and build planning and financial management capacity so that resources are allocated and spent more equitably and effectively. This means moving beyond project implementation to active engagement in budget planning cycles, public expenditure reviews, and results-based financing with a focus on learning outcomes. Country office engagement will be embedded in national planning processes, not positioned alongside them.

Underpinning this is a strategic shift from measurement to the active use of learning data. UNICEF will build the global evidence base on what works in data use, strengthen evidence-to-policy linkages at all system levels, and develop practical guidance tailored to real country constraints. Recognizing that better data alone does not lead to better policy, UNICEF will support governments to foster a culture of evidence-informed policymaking in which data are routinely used to identify disparities, set priorities, allocate resources, monitor implementation and drive continuous improvement. This includes strengthening evidence-to-policy linkages at all levels of the system, supporting leadership and institutional capacities for data use, and developing practical guidance tailored to real country constraints. The approach spans system-level data use for policy and resource allocation, formative assessment and teacher-facing data at classroom level, AI-enabled identification of learning patterns, and expanded skills measurement beyond literacy and numeracy to include socio-emotional, digital, and transferable skills. Where IFIs and MDBs provide loans for education reform, or the EU provides direct budget support to governments, UNICEF will serve as a trusted technical partner, supporting governments to translate data and evidence into effective policy, equitable resource allocation, quality

implementation and measurable learning results.

Private Sector and Philanthropic Partnerships

Private investment in education is growing rapidly, but it is fragmented, often misaligned with equity goals, and concentrated in markets that serve already-advantaged learners. UNICEF's role is not simply to attract these resources into its own portfolio, but to contribute to shape where and how they are deployed toward equitable learning outcomes for populations that market incentives alone cannot reach.

Technology and Private Capital. Technology firms, particularly those developing AI and digital learning tools, represent the fastest growing and most consequential source of private capital entering education. This investment brings both opportunity and risk: without deliberate shaping, they could continue to flow towards commercial markets leaving behind underserved populations. UNICEF will engage technology firms through LEARN AI Global Compact, to align AI and EdTech investment with equity standards, local language and curriculum requirements, and measurable learning outcomes. UNICEF has no vested interest in any technology provider, which is the foundation of its credibility in this role.

Impact Investment and Blended Finance. UNICEF will work with impact investors and development finance institutions to design financing instruments, including blended finance and outcome-based mechanisms, that mobilize private capital for public education goals. The focus is on instruments that crowd in investment at scale, link the cost of capital to measurable learning outcomes, and are designed to reach contexts and populations that commercial returns alone would not justify.

Philanthropic Partnerships. Foundations and philanthropies remain a critical source of flexible, risk-tolerant capital. UNICEF will engage them to coordinate financing toward system-level outcomes rather than fragmented pilots, and to align their investments with

national education priorities and UNICEF's programmatic frameworks.

Multilateral Governance. UNICEF holds governance roles within key multilateral education financing mechanisms, including the Global Partnership for Education and Education Cannot Wait. As co-lead of the Global Education Cluster, UNICEF coordinates humanitarian education response and will use that position to ensure humanitarian financing increasingly builds toward national systems rather than entrenching parallel structures. This position has not always been fully leveraged. The shift required is from

competitive grant recipient toward strategic governance actor, contributing to shaping funding priorities, eligibility frameworks, and results frameworks in line with equity imperatives and country-level evidence. The same logic applies to other funding modalities, such as the International Finance Facility for Education and the Education Outcomes Fund, which will be engaged systematically as part of a coherent financing strategy rather than opportunistically through isolated proposals. Country offices carry a defined role in building the programmatic case at national level that attracts, justifies, and shapes these financing flows.

BOX 3 LEARN AI Global Compact: A Flagship Initiative for Aligned Investment in Education

LEARN AI Global Compact, Learning Equity and Access through Responsible AI, is UNICEF's flagship initiative for mobilizing aligned investment in AI-enabled education at scale. It is designed as a response to a structural problem: global AI investment is expanding rapidly, reaching approximately 1.5 trillion dollars in 2025, while the education systems that enable populations to benefit from that investment remain chronically underfunded. Without sufficient investment in learning, the expansion of AI technologies risks generating returns that bypass most of the world's population.

LEARN AI Global Compact addresses this through a compact model that brings together governments, technology providers, multilateral institutions, and communities around explicit, transparent commitments to advance learning through responsible AI. The compact is organized around three workstreams. The first focuses on technical products and benchmarks, including an AI for Learning Industry Compact with time-bound commitments from AI firms, co-development of performance benchmarks appropriate for low- and middle-income country contexts, and shared standards for AI in education. The second addresses financing, deploying a hybrid capital architecture that combines private sector investment, multilateral finance, and government education budgets, with sustainability-linked bonds and outcome-based financing instruments that tie the cost of capital to measurable learning outcomes. The third workstream covers a global movement and engagement, building the political will and institutional trust required for responsible AI adoption in education systems, led by teachers and young people.

Governance is designed to operate at the highest political level, engaging heads of state, leaders of AI firms, heads of multilateral institutions, and representatives of teachers and young people.

LEARN AI Global Compact represents UNICEF's most concrete expression of a global public good, with new financing logic for education, mobilizing and aligning the capital that already exists toward learning outcomes for the children who need it most, while recognizing that countries will require differentiated transition pathways based on digital readiness, infrastructure, and institutional capacity.

Dimension 2: Centres of Excellence: Operational Delivery at Scale

UNICEF has provided technical support to governments on education for decades. What changes now is the targeting, the nature of the offer, and the deployment model. The CoEs represent a fundamental shift in how UNICEF decides where to engage and how to engage.

Differentiated Country Engagement

Technical support will be provided based on country needs and evidence. UNICEF has developed a country typology that classifies

158 countries across three dimensions directly linked to the Strategic Plan targets: access to education, learning outcomes, and skills for work and life (see Figure 3). Each country is positioned within an eight-group matrix¹⁰ according to where it is challenged and where it is performing comparatively better. Additional lenses refine this classification. For instance, the degree of contextual disruption from conflict, climate, and fragility; efficiency, measured as the gap between actual education performance and what is expected, given the available resources; access to connectivity; and equity, capturing the distribution of outcomes across population groups.

Figure 3 Typology of Countries Based on Strategic Plan 2026–2029 Education Results





This typology is not a substitute for country-led priority setting. Country offices remain UNICEF's primary interface with governments and national education systems and are best placed to understand political economy dynamics, reform opportunities and emerging priorities that may not be fully captured through global classifications. The purpose of the typology is therefore to inform and strengthen technical assistance, while maintaining the flexibility to respond to country-specific contexts, government demand and regional realities.

The typology does two things that are operationally new. First, it guides the nature of CoE engagement for each country. A country challenged with access and operating in a fragile context requires a different offer than a middle-income country with adequate enrollment but poor learning outcomes. Second, it aligns resource allocation to Strategic Plan monitoring, ensuring that the deployment of technical assistance has a direct impact on the 350 million more children target.

This alignment will be balanced by safeguards that ensure countries with smaller populations, unique contexts or highly specific reform priorities continue to receive high-quality support and access to global expertise. UNICEF's comparative advantage lies in combining responsiveness to country realities with progress toward global goals, and the differentiated engagement model is intended to reinforce, rather than diminish, that balance.

Furthermore, the typology is not static and moreover countries can fit into more than one category, especially given the in-country diversity in learning. It will be updated periodically using the Strategic Plan and the SDG indicators from international sources, without requiring additional data collection from country offices. Where data gaps exist, estimates are used while simultaneously generating an incentive for countries to strengthen their own reporting systems, in relation to learning outcomes and other SDG indicators for education.

From Implementation to Catalytic Technical Assistance

The CoE offer spans six areas of technical assistance: policy reform and programme design; financing for scale; digital infrastructure and EdTech; humanitarian response and resilience; teacher workforce development and institution building; and equity and demand generation. These areas are not new to UNICEF. What is new is the operating principle governing how UNICEF engages within them.

The CoE applies four criteria to determine whether an engagement is genuinely catalytic: it must generate a multiplier effect, where UNICEF's investment triggers government resource and implementation commitment at a scale UNICEF cannot itself provide; it must add value beyond existing efforts rather than duplicate what another partner is already funding; it must draw on technical expertise that exceeds what the government can access domestically; and it must be designed for scale from inception, with government ownership from the outset, affordable unit costs, outcomes measurement embedded and a phase-out plan built in from the start. Locally-driven innovations, including multi-shift schooling, multi-grade teaching, community learning centres, and flexible scheduling models, represent a priority category for catalytic engagement. These approaches expand access and improve outcomes within existing resource envelopes, without requiring proportional increases in public expenditure, and are well-suited to the scale and sustainability criteria the CoE applies.

These criteria are designed to reorient technical support and the demand for it. The starting point for any new engagement is whether it meets the catalytic threshold. Where direct implementation remains necessary, as in humanitarian contexts or fragile states where government capacity is limited, it should be explicitly framed within a systems-strengthening trajectory and with a defined transition plan.

The value proposition for country offices is threefold. First, CoEs provide access to specialized expertise, global evidence and implementation experience that may not be readily available at country level. Second, they help country offices navigate complex policy, financing, partnership and systems challenges that require multidisciplinary support. Third, they offer an independent perspective to help assess whether proposed interventions are likely to achieve scale, sustainability and system-level impact.

Strengthening the CoEs is not intended to substitute for country-level capacity. Rather, it is intended to complement and augment it. The CoEs will provide globally pooled expertise that can be deployed strategically to support CO functions, while helping build sustainable technical capacity within country teams over time. Resource allocation should therefore be understood as a dual investment: maintaining strong country presence and influence while strengthening access to specialized expertise that can be mobilized where and when it is most needed.

The CoE performance should ultimately be assessed from the perspective of country offices and the systems they support. Measures could include quality, usefulness, timeliness, uptake and catalytic contribution of their support.

Over time, the balance of country office engagement should shift decisively toward policy accompaniment, budget engagement, and systems design. The measure of progress is not how many children UNICEF directly reaches but the degree to which government systems are increasingly delivering at scale as a result of UNICEF's engagement. This approach is aligned with the education indicators of the Strategic Plan, ensuring UNICEF capacity to monitor progress accordingly.

A Networked Hub Model

The CoE network operates through four locations: Amman, Nairobi, Bangkok, and Panama, with shared functions in Helsinki and New York. Each location consolidates thematic expertise across the six offers rather than organizing it by country portfolio. This structural shift means that a country office facing a specific challenge in, for example, education financing reform or teacher workforce development, accesses the relevant specialist directly through the CoE network, regardless of which location holds that expertise.

The networked model consists of a globally pooled offer that can be deployed flexibly and at speed. Over 800 national and international staff across 122 country offices will operate within this architecture, coordinated through a demand and supply system that matches country office needs against CoE capacity. Country Focal Points across the pillars carry defined country responsibilities informed by the typology, their linguistic skills, and prior country experience, ensuring continuity of engagement.

This model and the typology (with its lenses) also enable cross-CoE collaboration. Countries requiring simultaneous engagement on education financing and social policy, disability inclusion as per the DIPAS, adolescent girls' education as per the Gender Equality Action Plan, or on digital infrastructure and data systems, can access coordinated support across UNICEF's CoEs without country offices navigating multiple separate relationships. The Education CoE will maintain dedicated liaison functions for this purpose, ensuring that the complexity of a country's needs does not fragment the quality of UNICEF's response.

To deliver on this ambition, an assessment of the current human resources was conducted, pointing to five strategic priorities for the workforce agenda: creating the conditions for staff to focus on catalytic systems work beyond grant administration; strengthening support for nationally led teams; aligning

staffing models more closely with operational complexity and emergency demands; building a stronger leadership and succession pipeline, particularly for national staff; and adapting workforce models to the evolving humanitarian architecture and localization agenda.

Achieving our ambition will also require significant investment in UNICEF's own capabilities. The Centres of Excellence will therefore serve not only as repositories of specialized expertise but also as platforms for systematic capacity development across country offices, recognizing that significant technical talent and contextual knowledge already resides in country office teams. Through dedicated training and learning programmes, communities of practice, mentoring, and hands-on engagement in country reform processes, the CoEs will help build staff competencies in education financing, public financial management, data and digital architecture, results-based financing, policy implementation, political economy analysis, and oversight of large-scale investment operations. Particular attention will be given to strengthening UNICEF's ability to serve as a trusted technical assistance partner in contexts where development financing is increasingly provided through loans or budget support mechanisms, requiring sophisticated technical and financial engagement with governments, IFIs and MDBs.

Alongside upskilling and reskilling staff, UNICEF will review operational modalities, talent profiles and deployment models to ensure that technical expertise can be mobilized rapidly and efficiently. The objective is to build a workforce that is fit for purpose in the next generation of education reform, capable of supporting governments not only to deliver programmes, but also to design, finance and implement system transformation at scale.

Advancing Thought Leadership: Generating and Translating Evidence for Education Reform

UNICEF occupies a unique position in the global knowledge architecture for education. With programming experience across more than 140 countries, spanning humanitarian and development contexts simultaneously, UNICEF generates and applies evidence at a scale and breadth that no other education actor can match. This evidence base, from community learning centres in conflict-affected settings to AI-enabled tutoring pilots in middle-income countries, from foundational learning interventions in the earliest grades to pathways for out-of-school adolescents, is one of UNICEF's most underutilized assets. Thought leadership is the commitment to systematically generate, synthesize, and translate that knowledge into the policy and practice changes that the learning crisis demands.

The 21st century demands a radical rethinking of education. The current school model, a relic of the Industrial Revolution, is ill-equipped to nurture the knowledge and skills needed for economically empowered and engaged global citizens. It prioritizes uniformity over individual needs, failing to adapt to rapid technological advancements. This outdated system must be replaced with a model that embraces the science of learning, the unique needs of every learner, fosters creativity and critical thinking and problem-solving, and prepares students for a future shaped by climate change, technological disruption, and quickly evolving global dynamics.

What does the evidence tell us about how children actually learn, and how far are

current education systems from acting on it? Neuroscience, cognitive science and decades of programmatic experience have produced a sophisticated understanding of how the brain develops, how foundational skills are acquired, and what conditions support or undermine learning across the life course. UNICEF will build and communicate the case for education systems grounded in the science of learning, covering the design of learning environments, the sequencing of skills development, the role of play and socio-emotional learning, and the conditions under which children who have fallen behind can recover lost ground. This includes critically examining inherited assumptions about the classroom itself, whether the physical and pedagogical structures through which most children experience schooling are fit for the learning that 21st century life and work demand.

What does quality teaching look like across the full range of contexts in which children learn, and what does it take to achieve it at scale? The evidence on effective teaching is stronger than it has ever been. Structured pedagogy, teaching at the right level, formative assessment, and teacher coaching models have demonstrated measurable impact across diverse settings. Yet this evidence has not translated into system-level reform at the pace or scale the learning crisis requires. UNICEF will advance a rigorous, context-sensitive agenda on the teaching profession, examining what works in formal school systems, in low-resource and multilingual environments, in humanitarian settings where community

Questions driving our thought leadership agenda:

- Is it time to rethink the very concept of the “classroom” to create learning spaces that are more engaging, flexible and relevant to the needs of today’s students and preparing them to be future ready?
- The classroom, one of the pillars of the current education system, with its rows of desks facing a teacher, is designed for mass instruction and standardized testing. However, it predates the significant advancements in cognitive science. The modern understanding of how the brain learns challenges many of the assumptions underlying the traditional classroom structure.
- Could it then be considered that the classroom is preparing children for an outdated economy and unable to actualize the potential of the human brain for learning and acquisition of skills and competencies?

and volunteer teachers carry the burden of learning continuity, and in the emerging landscape where AI tools are reshaping what teachers are asked to do. The objective is not to produce an additional framework for teacher development, but to build the evidence base and political case for the sustained investment in teaching that children in every context deserve.

Under what conditions does AI genuinely improve learning outcomes for the most marginalized children, and what governance frameworks are required to ensure it does so equitably? AI is entering education systems at a moment when the evidence base for its impact remains nascent and the risks of inequitable deployment are significant. UNICEF is positioned to lead the global effort to build that evidence base rigorously and independently, with particular attention to low-resource contexts, multilingual environments, and the humanitarian settings that commercial AI development does not reach. Through LEARN AI Global Compact and its broader partnerships, UNICEF will generate and disseminate evidence on which AI tools work, for whom, under what infrastructure and pedagogical conditions, and with what safeguards, making that evidence a global public good available to governments, partners and civil society.

Across these and other areas, UNICEF’s thought leadership will be grounded in its programmatic experience and expressed through multiple channels: peer-reviewed research and policy analysis, high-level global and regional convenings, government accompaniment in policy dialogue, and the Champion Countries initiative through which implementation learning will be systematically captured and shared. UNICEF will ensure that the voices of children, adolescents, teachers and communities are central to this agenda, not as recipients of knowledge generated elsewhere, but as sources of evidence about what education reform must deliver and how.

The measure of UNICEF’s thought leadership is the degree to which that knowledge contributes to shaping what governments decide, what partners finance, and what children experience in learning.

Conclusion

This strategy presents the vision for UNICEF in a new era of development cooperation, changing demands on the global education system, and the unmissable opportunities to reform education. It presents an achievable ambition for children and young people and positions UNICEF as a collaborative leader to build a global learner-centred education ecosystem that can drive sustainable progress for generations to come. With its adoption and embrace by the leadership of the organization, it is possible to envision a future led by UNICEF that makes quality learning not just an aspiration but a reality for every child and youth.



Endnotes

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- 7 Aguayo, V. and Britto, P.R. 2024. ‘The first and next 1000 days: A continuum for child development in early life’. *The Lancet*. Available at: [https://doi.org/10.1016/S0140-6736\(24\)02439-5](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0140-6736(24)02439-5).
- 8 UNICEF and the international community recommend to all Governments «the allocation of at least 10 per cent of education expenditure to pre-preprimary education, and prioritize and reorient public expenditures for ECCE to focus on the poorest and most disadvantaged. Available at: <https://globalallianceforcare.org/en/community/resources/574-global-resource-153.html?view=obj>.
- 9 The Humanitarian Reset is an Inter-Agency Standing Committee (IASC) initiative launched in 2025 to reform the international aid system. Available at: <https://interagencystandingcommittee.org/humanitarian-reset>.
- 10 One group with the “highest burden” countries which are comparatively more challenged in the three dimensions (access, learning and skills); three groups with countries more challenged in two of the three dimensions; three groups with countries more challenged in only one dimension; and one group with countries less challenged across all three dimensions but which may still require targeted support.

for every child

Whoever she is.

Wherever he lives.

Every child deserves a childhood.

A future.

A fair chance.

That's why UNICEF is there.

For each and every child.

Working day in and day out.

In more than 190 countries and territories.

Reaching the hardest to reach.

The furthest from help.

The most excluded.

It's why we stay to the end.

And never give up.



for every child